THE PRICE OF DAWN — SESSION 5: THE PRICE OF DAWN

Official GM Adventure Module · Level 8 (Campaign Climax · 5 Gestalt PCs) · Dilemma: *When the 'right' choice and the 'good' choice are different, which do you make?*

SESSION 5 - THE PRICE OF DAWN (LEVEL 8)

Premise: When the "right" choice and the "good" choice are different, which do you make?

Level: 8 · **Players:** 4–6 · **Time:** 3.5–4.5 hrs · **Type:** Investigation, Dramatic Roleplay, Tactical Combat, Campaign Climax

QUICK REFERENCE CARD

GM Balance Note: 5 Gestalt Level 7 Characters (10-Player Equivalent)

This session is tuned for **5 Gestalt Level 7 characters**. Because dual-class characters possess double the resource pool, features, and action synergies, they should be balanced as **10 Level 7 characters** (Deadly Encounter Budget: **17,000+ XP**). - Bosses and elite commanders possess **Legendary Resistances**, **Anti-Magic auras**, and **high HP pools** (175–195 HP) to prevent single-turn shutdowns from focused smites and burst spells. - Use the provided GM tactics and focus fire on isolated party members to maintain dramatic tension.

Level	8 · ~3–4 hours · Opener + 5 scenes + Ritual Moment
Session dilemma	When the "right" choice and the "good" choice are different, which do you make?
Session arc	Assembly → Confrontation → Positions → Declaration → Signal
Ritual paths	B (all 11): Inversion - sun returns, all live · A (8–10): Sacrifice - some gone · C: Transfer · D: Refusal · E: Cascade

NPC	WANT	FEAR	LIE
Harran Lecht	To have done enough	That he has run out of time to stop	*"I have no choice left"*
Senna Kard	This to end without more death	That her caution is just cowardice	She doesn't care which ending; she cares about this specific one
Ellan Voss	To say yes at the right moment	That the right moment has already passed	*"I haven't decided yet"*
Tomas Areth	The circle to close, nothing held back	That his memorized sequence has a flaw	He is not afraid
Ysel Maren	Every voice to be genuinely free	That Cormac's uncertainty is contagious	She is not frightened herself

FACTION STATUS - SESSION 5 START

The Dawnless (Concordance of the Withdrawn) Their long game was Ellan's permanent refusal. Once she steps onto the plaza (or once word reaches them she intends to) they know they have lost the position they held for three years. They do not mount an attack. One watcher is visible at the plaza's western edge throughout the session. If players confront her: she steps back without speaking. They are done.

The Solennite Blades / Keseph Vyne If exposed in Session 4 (contract recovered): Keseph is under informal Compact inquiry. No Blades appear. He does not attend the ritual. He waits to see what authority looks like in a city with a sun. If not exposed: 2 Blades in Scene 1 (Spy stat block). After the ritual, players may confront Keseph directly - he capitulates immediately. The sun changes his leverage position entirely. He was protecting an arrangement built for permanent twilight. That arrangement no longer exists.

The Reckoning Harran is in Scenes 1 and 5. After he goes down and the ritual completes, the Reckoning fractures within hours. Some soldiers join the plaza crowd to watch the sun rise. Others leave the city without explanation. The organization dissolves into individual decisions.

SESSION OPENER - THE MORNING OF THE RITUAL

Players have had the 48-hour window Harran negotiated (or the Chancellor's remaining days). The morning of the ritual has arrived.

The State of the Vessel (Corven's Concordance Stone):
The party carries the octagonal ritual vessel recovered in Session 4. - **For tables with 2 cubes collected (Sera Voss & Aldric Stone the Dwarven Blacksmith):**
Only 2 sockets hum with warm light (Slot 1 - Sera Voss and Slot 8 - Aldric Stone). Six slots remain cold. - **The 4 Resolved Dawnborn (Tomas Areth, Ysel Maren, Nin Fletch, Orya Doss):** These four have already resolved their choice and do not require separate fetch quests across the city. They arrive independently at the Ashring plaza perimeter at dawn, carrying their cubes (Cubes 2, 4, 7, and 8). When the party brings the Concordance Stone to the dais, these four Dawnborn step forward to hand over their cubes with brief, moving character moments. - **The 4 Active Dilemmas (Petra, Davin, Lira, Cormac):** These are the four Dawnborn who require the party's active intervention, conversation, or rescue this morning before they will come to the circle. - **For tables with more cubes collected:** Simply skip whichever Dawnborn the party already visited.

The morning begins with the party resolving these final four Dawnborn across the city in **Morning Assembly** before bringing the completed vessel to the central dais.

What the Ritual Was Actually Trying to Do

GM context - read before running this session.

Corven's plan was simple in principle and catastrophic in execution. Varenhold was already famous for its amber light. Corven believed the city's geography (crossroads of three trade routes, the specific stone composition of the Ashring, the angle of the valley) made it possible to permanently anchor the sun's warmth to the city. Not magic. Engineering. The ritual would use ten freely-consenting people born in Varenhold as living conduits: they would channel the city's ambient solar energy into the Primer Stones and fix it there permanently. A second sun, rooted in the Ashring. The amber workshops forever. The city's golden age, preserved against entropy and politics and whatever came next.

When Ellan withdrew, nine consents had already begun to flow. The energy couldn't complete - but it couldn't return either. Nine had given everything. It stayed. Trapped in the stones, in the sky, in the blood of everyone born that night. Eternal twilight is Corven's ritual frozen mid-dawn: almost enough, not quite.

The Inversion is not an undoing. It is a completion. Fifty years late, with the element that was always missing.

What Theron actually did: Eleven years ago, Theron Waide found Ellan Voss's account of the stillbirth in a restricted Archive record. He located the preserved remains (the ritual's overflow energy had kept them intact in a way that shouldn't have been possible) and used Corven's technique to restart the child's heart. He told himself he was saving a life. He was also, without understanding it, borrowing a piece of the ritual's trapped light to do it.

The other Dawnborn carry the ritual energy the way water is carried in a vessel. The vessel and the water are separate things. When the Inversion completes, the water returns to the sky and the vessels remain.

Ixa is not a vessel. When Theron used the ritual energy to revive her, the energy did not pass through her - it became her. Her heartbeat is the ritual's heartbeat. Her warmth is the trapped dawn. When the Inversion completes and the light returns to the sky, she returns with it.

Theron knows this. He has known for three months. He told Edoran. He has not told anyone else. This is his guilt, not the revival, but what he understands now about what the revival was.

What Ixa knows: Edoran told her. Three months ago. She asked him directly, and he couldn't lie to her. She has had three months to make her choice. She is at the plaza this morning not because she was summoned. She decided to come.

She is the only person in the Ashring who has had time to fully examine what she is willing to do. She is not performing courage. She is not rushing toward anything. She is simply present, watching, waiting for the right moment - which she has understood, since Edoran told her, is not hers to create. It belongs to someone else.

What players know: Whatever they've figured out. If they ask Edoran directly, he tells them - quietly, precisely, once. If they ask Ixa directly, she tells them too. She does not soften it. She does not ask them to make it easier. If they don't ask: they may not know until after.

GM note on player agency: If players know and still complete the ritual (if they extend a hand knowing what it costs) that is one kind of story. If players don't know and the dawn rises and then they understand - that is another. Both are valid. This is the last session. Let the table choose the version they're in.

Five Senses & Setup

Setup: Not-quite-dawn. Amber-shift - what passes for morning in Varenhold. The Ashring plaza is already filling. The Dawnborn have been arriving since before the amber came up. The activation work from Session 4 has primed the stones; they are not glowing yet, but the air around each one is warmer than it should be.

Five senses: - Sight: Amber light on the stones, warmer than ambient. The plaza crowd keeping a respectful distance from the circle - not frightened, not festive. Waiting. - Sound: The city behind the plaza. Not celebrating. Held breath. - Smell: Cold stone, ozone sharper than yesterday. And bread from the Dawnhall kitchen, someone baked because they didn't know what else to do. - Touch: Flagstones slightly warm from the stones' ambient charge. Present. Faint. - Air: Stiller than usual. Even the harbor draft has stopped.

The 11th Dawnborn - Ixa

The count comes up wrong.

Ten Primer Stones are assigned - each stone warming when its Dawnborn approaches. But there is an eleventh stone: no name, no warmth, standing slightly apart from the circle's geometry. And there are eleven people carrying something from the original ritual.

No one raises it directly. Players who count will find it.

If players raise it: Edoran, at the plaza edge, quietly: *"We found the eleventh three months ago. We didn't know what to do with it."*

The eleventh is Ixa. The original ritual was designed for ten. It failed with nine. What no one knew (what Corven couldn't have known) was that the tenth's refusal was not defiance but love: Ellan withdrew because she was carrying a child, and the child was the ritual's missing piece made flesh before she had a name for it. Ixa was always the eleventh. She wasn't born in time. That's all. Fifty years late. Still here.

Physical: The party knows her. She is tabaxi, adult, carrying the Crucible's ash-tattoos on her neck and shoulder - the scars of her birth and everything the Crucible made her survive afterward. Her hands are always warmer than the room. Not fever-warm. Consistently, inexplicably warmer. People who shake her hand sometimes look down at it afterward. She notices. She has always noticed.

She was dead at birth. The ritual's overflow energy kept something intact. Theron used it to restart her heart. The energy that revived her did not pass through her - it became her. Her warmth is the trapped dawn. Her heartbeat is the ritual's heartbeat. She has been alive her entire life powered by a piece of unfinished daybreak, and the Crucible spent years studying why their asset ran warm and never understood what they were measuring.

The stone warms when she approaches it. Edoran found out three months ago. He told Theron. Theron told him he had already known for longer. That conversation is visible in Edoran's face, the specific expression of someone who has been carrying something they cannot put down.

GM note: Ixa knows. She has known for three months. She is here because she decided to come. Give her player a breath before explaining anything to the table. This is not a combat reveal.

Who Steps Back

With eleven Dawnborn and eleven stones, the original question of "who yields" transforms. No one steps back. But the reason no one has to die (the reason Ending B exists at all) is because Ixa does.

This is the arithmetic players have been doing wrong. They thought the choice was: which nine of ten survive. The real choice is: all ten survive, and the eleventh, who was not meant to be here at all, returns to where she came from. She was borrowed. The light borrowed her. The ritual's completion is the settling of that debt - not with grief, but with consent. Hers.

GM note: This is the campaign's final reversal. Five sessions about consent, sacrifice, and the arithmetic of who gets left out. The last answer is: no one gets left out. Everyone who was supposed to be here is here. Ixa included, who was never supposed to be here, and who is here anyway, and who gets to choose what that means.

The love that stopped the ritual is the same love that completes it. Ellan refused because she was carrying Ixa. Ixa completes the circle because she chooses to. She is not a victim of the ritual. She is not a sacrifice demanded by the city or by Corven or by anyone. She is a person who has had three months and made a decision. That is all. That is everything.

If Ellan is present: she steps onto her stone without speaking. She has been waiting fifty years to do this freely. She does not make it large. If a player is watching her face when she sees Ixa standing at the 11th stone (the stone that could only exist because she once refused) it is the expression of someone for whom everything finally makes a terrible, perfect sense.

"I stepped away once. I am done stepping away."

She steps on.

Varren Aldiss - Optional

Players who investigate Session 4's revealed intelligence (Harran's Spire contact who was double-feeding) can expose Aldiss before combat begins. DC 14 Investigation (Tomas's journal + Spire records) or DC 16 Persuasion (direct confrontation).

If exposed: Harran arrives in Scene 1 without his intelligence advantage. He doesn't know the stone positions are primed. He wastes his opening action recalibrating, no stat block change, just a narrative disadvantage.

MORNING ASSEMBLY - THE FINAL CUBES & CONSENTS

The Dawnborn who need the party's intervention on the morning of the ritual before the circle can be sealed. Each scene is grounded in Graeme Sherwood / theGreatGM principles: distinct five-senses atmosphere, stakes, NPC Want/Fear/Lie, and an encounter beat.

> *[!TIP]* ***GM Pacing Note: Running with 2 Cubes Collected (Sera Voss & Aldric Stone)*** *If your players enter Session 5 with only 2 cubes (Sera Voss and Aldric Stone the blacksmith),* ***do not send them on eight separate errands****. - Run the* ***4 Active Encounters*** *below: Petra (rescued from Greenhollow), Davin (convinced on the Bastion Wall), Lira (reassured at the Healing House), and Cormac (grounded in the Dawnhall). - The remaining four (Tomas, Ysel, Nin, Orya) are already resolute and arrive directly at the Ashring plaza at dawn to deliver their cubes when the party returns to seat the vessel on the central dais. This keeps the morning prep focused, atmospheric, and playable in ~45–60 minutes.*

Petra Vane - The Missing One in Greenhollow (Stone 6)

Want: To find peace without being coerced into martyrdom by either the city or the Reckoning.
Fear: Being cornered and forced to make a permanent choice before she has found her footing.
Lie: "I'm just an herbalist now. The stones forgot about me thirty years ago."

Physical: Early fifties, lean, silver-streaked hair bound in leather cord. Soil-stained fingertips, sharp herbalist's smock over travel clothes. She holds herself like someone who has spent weeks listening for the sound of boots on her gravel path.

Location: Greenhollow Village, Dusk Parishes (a half-hour ride through the dense twilight mist outside the Ashring wall). A damp settlement of slate-roofed cottages clustered around a dying, overgrown wayside shrine.

Five Senses & Setup: - *Sight:* A low timber apothecary cottage behind rows of drying glass bell-jars. Thick grey ground-fog curling around elderberry bushes. In the road behind the party: fresh horse tracks and boot prints—Reckoning scouts have been asking questions here this morning. - *Sound:* Rhythmic drip of condensation from slate eaves; the dry rustle of hanging lavender and marsh-mint bundles inside; distant crow calls. - *Smell:* Pungent dried rue, boiled wintergreen, sharp turpentine, damp peat. - *Touch:* Clammy, freezing parish mist clinging to skin; the cold iron latch of the apothecary door. - *Air:* Still, heavy with moisture and old incense from the nearby shrine.

The Approach: When players push open the creaking door of the cottage, the front counter is abandoned. A mortar and pestle sits half-ground on the counter, still moist.
- **DC 12 Perception or Survival:** Notice scuff marks on the floorboards leading behind a heavy hanging drying rack of silver-thistle.
- Behind the rack is a concealed cellar trapdoor, cracked open a fingernail's width. Petra is sitting on the steps below with a pruning sickle in her hand, listening to the room above.

When she sees the party (and sees they are not wearing Reckoning armbands): She exhales slowly, lowering the sickle.

> *"You aren't Harran's hounds. They were at the inn twenty minutes ago asking for 'the woman who survived the Year of Ash.' I went out the back window."*

She climbs back into the apothecary room, brushing cobwebs from her shoulder. Her eyes fix on the party's gear, then on Aldric's iron tokens or the Concordance Stone if visible.

> *"You came all the way out into the dark for me. Why? The city has nine other names. Varenhold has always been willing to round down."*

The Encounter Beat: Petra does not respond to civic guilt ("*Varenhold is dying*")—she watched Varenhold abandon the Dusk Parishes decades ago.
What unlocks her is **personal truth and unforced choice**:

1. **Aldric's Token:** If players present the forged iron token Aldric gave them:
   She takes the cold iron in both hands, testing the weight with her thumb.
   > *"Aldric made this. He tests every weld three times. If he gave you this, he believed you were asking, not drafting."*
2. **The Secret of Lira's Child:** If players mention Lira Anwick or the Healing House:
   Petra's composure breaks slightly. DC 13 Insight reveals she has been sending anonymous coin pouches to Lira for two years via parish couriers.
   > *"How is Lira? Did she… did she stay at the clinic, or did they take her to the circle already?"*
   When the party explains that Lira is waiting for her own moment of honest consent:
   > *"She was always stronger than me. I ran because I thought if I stayed in the city, someone would make the choice for me while I was sleeping."*

3. **The Inversion Pathway:** If players reveal the Inversion (that unanimous consent allows everyone to survive):
   She stares at them in absolute, stunned silence.
   > *"Say that again. You're telling me Corven didn't build an altar… he built a bridge?"*

The Resolution: She reaches into a hollowed-out timber beam above the hearth and pulls down a small velvet pouch. Inside is **Cube 6 (Stone 6)**. It is cold when she draws it, but as her fingers wrap around it, a faint green-gold luminescence pulses through the crystal facets.

> *"I've kept this buried for twelve years. I thought if I forgot where I put it, the stones would forget me too. Take me back with you. I'm not letting Lira stand in that circle alone."*

Outcome: Petra gathers her cloak and travels back to the Ashring with the party. Flag: **"Petra: Willing & Present"**.

Davin Shore - The Veteran's Vigil on the Bastion Wall (Stone 10)

Want: To make one final, meaningful choice as a free man before the choice is stripped from him by age or force.
Fear: That his death will be wasted on political theater or another failed compromise.
Lie: "I'm just an old watchman pulling a cold shift. It doesn't matter what I think."

Physical: Mid-sixties, grizzled, broad-chested soldier's posture weathered by three decades in chain and boiled leather. Deep laugh lines carved into a face that has seen too many sieges. An unlit clay pipe clenched between his teeth.

Location: The East Rampart of the Ashring Quarter—the high stone battlement overlooking the twilight boundary where the city's cobblestones give way to the desolate grey plains.

Five Senses & Setup: - *Sight:* A long stretch of ancient granite wall. Lanterns hanging every sixty feet, glowing dull amber through thick cloud. Davin leaning against a crenel, his heavy wool cloak pulled tight against the northern draft. - *Sound:* The steady scrape of his boot heel against the wall stone; the low, mournful moan of the wind blowing across the outer plains; a faint, persistent high-frequency hum vibrating in the air around him. - *Smell:* Bitter pipe leaf, wet wool, gun-oil, cold river mist. - *Touch:* Freezing granite parapet; the slight, physical vibration passing through the stone into your boots. - *Air:* Biting cold, thinner and cleaner than the smoky lower districts.

The Scene: Davin doesn't turn when the party climbs the watchtower steps. He taps his cold pipe against the battlement stone.

> *"Hear that?"*

He points his pipe stem toward his own sternum, then toward the distant, silhouetted monolithic rings of the Ashring below.

> *"Been hummin' like a struck tuning fork inside my ribs for fourteen months. First I thought it was lung rot from the damp. Then the stones started waking up three days ago, and the hum turned into a drumbeat. I know why you're here. You've got Corven's box."*

He turns to face them. His eyes are clear, steady, and utterly without fear.

> *"I've had sixty-four years. Seen three wars, buried two regiments, and watched this city chew through good people like cordwood. If the sun needs ten coals to light the hearth, my coal's ready. I'm not afraid of the fire. But I need to know one thing: is Harran running this, or are you?"*

The Encounter Beat: Davin is an old soldier. Speeches about "hope" and "destiny" make him spit over the wall. He respects **tactical reality, command accountability, and the truth**.

- **If players explain the Reckoning's plan (forced blood sacrifice):**
  > *"Harran's a fool who thinks discipline can substitute for honor. You force a man onto that stone, the stone will choke on him. Corven's notes were clear on that much."*
- **The Inversion Reveal:** If players explain the Inversion pathway (Ending B: all 11 willing voices invert the loop, returning the sun without death):
  Davin freezes. The pipe slips from his calloused fingers, clattering onto the flagstones. For ten seconds, the old soldier does not breathe.
  > *"Say that one more time. Slowly. You're telling me… nobody has to die? None of the kids? Not Lira? Not young Tomas?"*
  He looks down at his weathered hands. A rough, trembling chuckle breaks out of his chest, growing into genuine, raspy laughter that echoes off the parapet.
  > *"Gods above. A soldier spends his whole life learning how to die well, and you come up here at the fifth bell to tell me I have to learn how to live in the sunlight. That's a damn sight harder."*

The Tactical Advice (GM Boon): He bends down, retrieves his pipe, and points toward the plaza below. > *"Listen to me. If Harran's moving, he'll hit from the East Gate where the road widens. He'll send veterans to pin the dais and skirmishers to drag Dawnborn off the perimeter stones. Don't let them split the circle. Keep someone at the dais to anchor the resonance, and put your heaviest fighter between Stone 3 and Stone 5—that's the blind spot where the market stalls bottleneck."*

The Cube: He unbuckles a brass-bound leather soldier's cartridge case from his belt and opens it. Nestled inside oiled sheepskin is **Cube 10 (Stone 10)**. It hums with deep, resonant vibrations that match the rhythm in his chest.
He hands it to the player who spoke to him:

> *"Take it. Put it where it belongs. I'll finish my watch, wash my face, and walk down to Stone 10 before the sixth bell rings. If we're bringing the sun back, I want to be looking right at it when it comes up."*

Outcome: Davin surrenders Cube 10. The party gains tactical advantage (+2 to initiative or positioning in Scene 1 Combat). Flag: **"Davin: Committed & Ready"**.

Lira Anwick - The Healing House Threshold (Stone 5)

Want: To make a decision she can live with, knowing her dependent is safe and will never doubt her love.
Fear: That her child will spend her life believing the city mattered more to her mother than she did.
Lie: "I need more time to prepare the tinctures." (She has been packed for two days; she is stalling out of terror for her daughter).

Physical: Late forties, worn but elegant features, hands stained with crushed comfrey and iodine. Her hair is pinned up with practical brass needles. She wears a thick travelling coat over her apothecary apron.

Location: The Lowmark Healing House steps, early morning before the first bells.

Five Senses & Setup: - *Sight:* Pale amber streetlights reflecting in wet gutter slush. Lira sitting alone on the frost-dusted limestone steps outside the clinic door. Through the leaded windowpane behind her, a small nine-year-old girl (Mira / Tevi) is visible sitting beside a warm brazier, reading an illustrated herbal, wrapped in a knitted wool shawl. - *Sound:* The quiet hiss of the street lantern burning down; distant iron wagon wheels echoing on cobbles; Lira's steady, rhythmic breathing in the chill air. - *Smell:* Boiling elderberry syrup, camphor, fresh carbolic soap, cold rain. - *Touch:* The bone-chilling cold of the stone step; the coarse wool of her coat. - *Air:* Crisp, still, smelling of imminent winter.

The Scene: She doesn't stand up when the party approaches. She looks up from her lap, where her hands are clasped tightly around a brass apothecary jar.

> *"She finished breakfast twenty minutes ago. I had her pack her little bag. Marit is taking her out to the river orchards at noon if… if things go the way the Council says they will."*

She looks at the leaded window, watching the child turn a page.

> *"I am not afraid of pain. I've stitched soldiers torn open by shrapnel and sat with dying children through the fever months. Dying is just the last procedure. What terrifies me is that Mira will grow up thinking I traded her for a sky full of strangers. How do you explain to a nine-year-old that you left her because you loved the world she has to live in?"*

The Encounter Beat: - If the party returned with Petra Vane or mentions Petra's support:
If the party tells Lira that Petra came back, or hands her the note Petra wrote in Greenhollow:
Lira stares at the handwriting. Her fingers tremble.
> *"Petra? She came back? She was hiding in the parishes for three weeks… and she came back for this?"*
She presses the parchment to her lips, closing her eyes.
> *"She told me two years ago I was a fool for believing anyone would ever stand with us. She kept sending coin for Mira anyway. That stubborn, beautiful idiot."* - **What players can promise:**
She does not want heroic platitudes (*"We'll protect everyone!"*). She wants a **specific, binding promise**: that someone will look after Mira if the ritual takes a toll, and that Mira will be told the absolute truth.
If a player character looks her in the eye and gives their personal word:
Lira exhales a breath she seems to have held for months. The tightness around her mouth softens into something fierce and resolute.

> *"Good. Hold to that. If I hear from the other side that you let her go hungry, I will find a way back through the veil just to haunt your boots."*

The Cube: She unscrews the brass jar. Inside, cushioned in raw dried chamomile blossoms, is **Cube 5 (Stone 5)**. The stone glows with a warm, steady amber pulse.
She places it into the party's hands:

> *"Tell Aldric to make sure my stone's clean. I'll walk down to the plaza as soon as I tuck her in with Marit. I'll be there."*

Outcome: Cube 5 is collected. Flag: **"Lira: Resolved & Peaceful"**.

Cormac Drell - The Dawnhall Back Room (Stone 4)

Want: To be certain his consent is honest and not just momentum, fear, or civic guilt.
Fear: That if he examines his reasons, they will break, and he will prove to be a coward.
Lie: "I've been ready for nine weeks. I just needed some tea before heading down."

Physical: Mid-fifties, heavy-set cabinetmaker with broad, scarred hands. Sitting at a plain pine table in the dim back room of the Dawnhall, hands flat on the wood, an untouched cup of cold tea beside him. He holds himself with the rigid stillness of someone trying not to shake.

Location: Dawnhall back room, Ashring Quarter (five minutes' walk from the circle).

Five Senses & Setup: - *Sight:* The rarely-used Dawnhall back room. One amber oil lamp guttering low on the table. Cormac sitting motionless, staring at his palms. - *Sound:* The distant clatter of pots in the kitchen two rooms over; inside the room, dead silence. - *Smell:* Cold bergamot tea, seasoned oak shavings, damp wool. - *Touch:* The door latch is freezing iron; the room itself is close and warm. - *Air:* Thick, heavy with the quiet of a man who has been sitting alone since before dawn.

The Approach: Before the ritual assembly, nine stones are responsive, but Stone 4 remains cold. Ysel Maren points toward the Dawnhall: *"I know where he is. I was waiting to see if someone else would go first."*

When players enter, Cormac looks up from the table. He doesn't apologize:

> *"I know. I told Edoran yes nine weeks ago and I meant it. And then it kept not being over, and I kept not examining it because examining it might break it. And then it was last night, and I examined it. The answer is still yes. I think. I'm not sure I know how to trust that it's yes for the right reason anymore."*

The Encounter Beat: Cormac does not need pressure, stakes, or speeches about the city. - **If players push urgency, civic duty, or logistics:** He lays his hands flat back on the wood.
> *"I've been sitting here since before dawn. Urgency isn't the thing I'm missing."* - **What resolves Cormac:** Simple presence and an unforced question without agenda:
"Why do you want to?"
He sits in long silence. Then:
> *"Because I said I would. And because the people who need me to have been patient long enough."*
He stands. *"I need you to walk to the stones with me. If I go alone, I'll stop."*

The Resolution & Cube: He unbuttons his vest and draws out **Cube 4 (Stone 4)**. As his thumb touches the face, a warm gold pulse runs through the crystal facets.
He hands it over:

> *"Take it. Put it in the box. I'm coming with you."*

Outcome: Cube 4 collected. Cormac walks to the Ashring with the party. Flag: **"Cormac: Reaffirmed & Grounded"**.

Seating the Cubes - The Projection of the Dawn Bird

Once all required cubes are gathered (Aldric, Tomas, Sera, Ysel, Cormac, Orya, Nin, Petra, Davin, Lira), the party holds the complete set of resonance vessels for Corven's Concordance Stone.

The Assembly on the Dais: The party brings the octagonal stone vessel to the central dais of the Ashring. Eight open sockets ring the rim. Each socket is carved with an archaic constellation glyph from the night of the First Ritual fifty years ago.

The Mechanical Order (Brightest to Dimmest / FREEWILL Acrostic): As decoded with Tomas Areth in Session 4: 1. **F** - *Fulgur* (Slot 1 - Sera Voss) 2. **R** - *Radix* (Slot 2 - Tomas Areth) 3. **E** - *Equus* (Slot 3 - Cormac Drell) 4. **E** - *Electrum* (Slot 4 - Ysel Maren) 5. **W** - *Warden* (Slot 5 - Lira Anwick) 6. **I** - *Ignis* (Slot 6 - Petra Vane) 7. **L** - *Limen* (Slot 7 - Nin Fletch) 8. **L** - *Lux* (Slot 8 / Stone 9 & 10 - Aldric Stone & Davin Shore)

The Sensory Transformation: - As each cube clicks home into its spring-loaded housing, an internal mechanism of counterweights and amber gears engages with a sharp, heavy *CHUCK*. - With 4 cubes seated: The vessel begins to vibrate, humming a low harmonic chord that vibrates in the teeth. - With 7 cubes seated: The octagonal stone grows searingly warm to the touch—not burning, but like a river stone baked in a summer sun that the city hasn't seen in half a century. - **When the 8th cube locks into place:**
A blinding needle of white-gold light shoots upward from the aperture at the top of the vessel. The light catches the low morning overcast and projects an enormous, breathtaking silhouette across the sky above Varenhold: **Corven's Dawn Bird**—wings spread wide, carrying the morning on its feathers.

The Plaza Reacts: Every person across the Ashring plaza looks up. In the crowd, gasps and whispers break out. Across the circle, every Primer Stone begins to thrum in sympathetic resonance, a golden aura rising six inches from the ancient granite.

And from the eastern approach road, the sound of marching iron boots begins.
The Reckoning has arrived.

THE FLOWERING - FINAL APPROACH

This scene triggers once on the morning of Session 5, after the plaza begins to fill, before the Puzzle section. It happens once. If the Flowering was fully resolved in Session 4 (Ixa engaged with the letter, players investigated the origin and ended the contact), skip this section.

Setup & The Gardener's Voice

The approach: A single figure arrives at the Ashring plaza edge - human or human-shaped, dressed in grey-green, wearing a pressed flower pinned visibly at the collar. One petal too many. They do not enter the circle of Primer Stones. They stop at the plaza's edge and wait.

They do not speak to the party. They speak, from thirty feet away, to Ixa.

Five senses: - *Sight:* The figure at the plaza edge, still as a post. The pressed flower pin visible even at distance. The crowd giving them space without understanding why. - *Sound:* When they speak: quiet, carrying, the voice of someone who has rehearsed patience for a very long time. - *Smell:* Something botanical. Not unpleasant. Not right. Same as the letter. - *Touch:* The air near them feels subtly thicker - not dangerous, just occupied. Something watching from behind their eyes. - *Air:* The stillness that happens just before a thing becomes irreversible.

The Gardener's Voice - this is not the Gardener. This is the Gardener's oldest emissary: a person who has been with the Flowering since before the experimentation began, who remembers when it was only a refuge, and who is not entirely sure it still is. They carry the Gardener's words. They believe them. They believe them the way you believe something you have been told since you were old enough to understand language.

Want: Ixa to come with them, not because of the ritual, but because she belongs with people who understand what she is. *Fear:* That she won't, and that the Gardener will send something worse. *Lie:* "We just want her to be with her own kind." The Gardener wants more than that. The Voice genuinely doesn't know what more means.

What the Voice says to Ixa - three beats. Let each breathe.

> *"We helped her conceive you. Your mother. Fifty years ago. We showed her it was possible. You are the outcome."*

One beat.

> *"We have been trying to make more outcomes like you. We have not always succeeded. The ones who did not succeed are still with us."*

One beat.

> *"Come with us. Or stop walking away. We will keep finding you. We always have."*

They wait.

This is Ixa's scene. The party can intervene (they should) but Ixa's response takes precedence. Whatever she says or does here is canon.

Resolution Paths

Path 1 - Ixa refuses (most likely).

She refuses. She can say why or not. Either way:

The Voice nods. *"The Gardener expected this. I didn't."* They step back once. A signal.

Two Grasping Tendrils emerge from the crowd - they have been there since before the party arrived. Same stat blocks as Session 4. Same objective: Ixa, unharmed, taken. One secondary objective: *prevent Ixa being removed from the plaza before combat ends.* If Ixa is grappled and carried beyond the plaza perimeter: Session 5's Ending B becomes unavailable. She returns but not in time for the activation sequence.

The Voice does not fight. They watch. If defeated or captured and spoken to: *"I was told she would want this eventually. I believed it. I'm not certain anymore."* They answer direct questions honestly - they know where the Flowering's compound is, they know who the Gardener is in general terms, they do not know what the failed experiments were trying to become.

Secondary objective (state before combat begins): Keep Ixa in the plaza. Hold her position against the Tendrils' Haul ability.

Path 2 - Ixa considers it.

The Voice steps forward. The Tendrils do not appear - yet. Ixa has until the end of the party's next round of conversation to decide.

If the party intervenes here: the Voice withdraws immediately. Tendrils appear. They read interference as a no.

If Ixa goes with them willingly: she leaves the plaza. The 11th stone is dark. Ending B is unavailable. The Flowering will not harm her - they genuinely want her with them. Retrieving Ixa becomes the session's new first priority.

Path 3 - Ixa says something unexpected.

If Ixa asks the Voice about the ones who did not succeed (asks what they became, asks if they are still alive) the Voice pauses. A longer pause than anything else so far.

> *"They are." A breath. "Barely."*

This is the crack in the Voice's certainty. Players who press here (DC 14 Persuasion, invoking what the Voice just revealed about their own doubt) can cause the Voice to withdraw voluntarily - *"I need to think about this."* - without triggering the Tendrils. This is the only route that ends without combat.

Combat Cards - Grasping Tendrils

Use the full stat blocks from Session 4 Scene 3b. Same creatures, same objectives, same Not Dead trait. The only addition:

Ashring Sensitivity. In the Ashring plaza, the Primer Stones' ambient charge gives any creature touching or grappling Ixa disadvantage on their Athletics checks to maintain the grapple - the stones are reading her as theirs and interfering. This does not help if the Tendril is beyond the plaza perimeter.

SCENE 1 - COMBAT: THE LAST STAND

Five Senses, Setup & Objectives

Setup: The Ashring at first light. The Dawn Bird has summoned the city and the Dawnborn to the plaza. Across the 40-foot circle, the Primer Stones hum with building charge. The Reckoning (or whoever the players didn't neutralize in Session 4) advances in disciplined formation from the East Approach Road to shatter the circle before the ritual can begin.

Five Senses: - *Sight:* Heavy dawn fog illuminated by amber street posts. Reckoning veterans advancing behind tower shields in two wedges. The Primer Stones glowing faint gold. - *Sound:* Iron greaves striking flagstones; shouts echoing off plaza walls; the deep, resonant drone of the stones waking up. - *Smell:* Sharp ozone and mineral dust; wet steel and oiled armor. - *Touch:* Flagstones vibrating beneath boots; sudden drafts of cold air stirring the banners. - *Air:* Charged and electric, like the seconds before a summer thunderstorm.

State all three secondary objectives before initiative is rolled:

Secondary Objectives: 1. **Hold the Perimeter Stones:** Reckoning soldiers attempt to pull Dawnborn from their positions (*Disrupt the Circle*). Each displaced Dawnborn must be guided back (DC 14 Persuasion, 1 action). 2. **Defend the Central Dais:** The dais is AC 15, 75 HP. If it takes 75+ damage from focused strikes, the activation inscription cracks (requires DC 18 Arcana on activation instead of automatic). 3. **Establish the Circle Signal:** The circle is 40 ft across. Players must agree on how the activation signal reaches all 11 positions through battle noise (horn, spell, or DC 14 Performance shout).

Enemies & Tactical Phases

Enemies Present: - **Reckoning Veterans (4–8):** Use 8 if Harran is active; 4 if his cell was disrupted in Session 4. - **Lieutenant Senna Kard (1):** Command officer on the field. Can be talked down (DC 15 Persuasion). - **Solennite Blade Infiltrators (0–2):** Present only if Keseph Vyne's contract was unrecovered in Session 4. They strike straight for the dais.

Tactical Phases: - *Round 1 (Formation):* Veterans advance behind tower shields in two wedges. Senna stays 20 ft back, shouting orders to drag Dawnborn rather than kill. - *Round 2 (Breaching):* Veterans use *Disrupt the Circle* to push Dawnborn from Stones 3 and 5. Blades (if present) Shadow Slip to the dais to hammer at the inscription. - *Round 3 (Moral Breaking Point):* If Senna is targeted or addressed directly with her core fear (*"You're killing the city to save your pride"*), she wavers. A DC 15 Persuasion check causes her to call a halt.

Combat End: Combat ends when Senna is downed or persuaded to stand down, or when half the Veterans fall and the remainder fail a DC 13 Wisdom save and retreat.

Combat Cards - Reckoning Veterans & Solennite Blades

RECKONING VETERAN *(×4 to 8)*
Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral
Hardened soldiers of Varenhold's garrison who believe the only way to save the city is to force the ritual through iron discipline.

AC 17 (splint mail) · **HP** 58 (9d8+18) · **Speed** 30 ft.
STR 16 (+3) · **DEX** 13 (+1) · **CON** 14 (+2) · **INT** 10 (+0) · **WIS** 11 (+0) · **CHA** 10 (+0)
Skills Athletics +5, Perception +2 · **Senses** Passive Perception 12 · **Languages** Common · **CR** 3 (700 XP)

TRAITS
Disrupt the Circle. When adjacent to a Dawnborn, the Veteran can use a bonus action to attempt an Athletics check (contested by the Dawnborn's Str/Dex save, DC 13) to drag or shove that Dawnborn up to 10 ft away from their Primer Stone.
Shield Wall. The Veteran gains +1 AC (included above) for each allied soldier wielding a shield within 5 ft (maximum +2).

ACTIONS
Multiattack. The Veteran makes two Longsword attacks or two Heavy Crossbow attacks.
Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d8+4) slashing damage, or 9 (1d10+4) versatile. *A heavy, professional military chop aimed to batter down guard.*
Heavy Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10+1) piercing damage.

REACTIONS
Interpose Shield. When an adjacent ally is targeted by an attack, the Veteran can impose disadvantage on the attack roll.

SOLENNITE BLADE INFILTRATOR *(×0 to 2)*
Medium humanoid (half-elf), neutral evil
Keseph Vyne's covert mercenaries tasked with sabotaging the ritual structure so the amber trade remains monopolized.

AC 15 (studded leather) · **HP** 44 (8d8+8) · **Speed** 35 ft.
STR 11 (+0) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 12 (+1) · **INT** 12 (+1) · **WIS** 10 (+0) · **CHA** 12 (+1)
Skills Stealth +7, Acrobatics +5 · **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12 · **Languages** Common, Elvish · **CR** 2 (450 XP)

TRAITS
Cunning Action. On each of its turns, the Blade can use a bonus action to Dash, Disengage, or Hide.
Saboteur's Precision. Weapon attacks deal an extra 7 (2d6) damage against inanimate ritual objects (such as the dais stone).
Sneak Attack (1/Turn). Deals an extra 7 (2d6) damage to a creature it hits with a weapon attack if it has advantage on the attack roll or an ally is within 5 ft.

ACTIONS
Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6+3) piercing damage + 3 (1d6) poison damage.

Lieutenant Senna Kard - Field Commander

LIEUTENANT SENNA KARD
Medium humanoid (human), neutral good (conflicted)
Second-in-command of the Reckoning. Exhausted, grief-stricken, and terrified that her loyalty has turned into slaughter.

AC 16 (studded leather + buckler) · **HP** 78 (12d8+24) · **Speed** 30 ft.
STR 14 (+2) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 14 (+2) · **INT** 12 (+1) · **WIS** 14 (+2) · **CHA** 15 (+2)
Saving Throws Dex +5, Wis +4 · **Skills** Insight +5, Persuasion +4, Perception +4
Senses Passive Perception 14 · **Languages** Common · **CR** 5 (1,800 XP)

TRAITS
Hesitant Blade. Senna does not want to slaughter civilians or Dawnborn. She fights defensively. If a player character spends their action speaking to her about the cost of this fight or her stated fear, she suffers disadvantage on all attack rolls until the start of her next turn.
Rally the Guard (Recharge 5–6). As a bonus action, Senna shouts an order. Up to three allied soldiers within 30 ft gain 10 temporary hit points and can move up to 15 ft without provoking opportunity attacks.

ACTIONS
Multiattack. Senna makes three Officer's Sabre attacks.
Officer's Sabre. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8+3) slashing damage. If the target is a Dawnborn, Senna chooses to deal non-lethal damage.
Order: Stand Down (1/Battle, Trigger: Talked Down). When a player succeeds on a DC 15 Persuasion check addressing her fear of meaningless slaughter, Senna drops her weapon and shouts: *"Hold your steel! Form ranks and hold! We are not butchers!"* All remaining Veterans cease offensive actions and take the Dodge action.

REACTIONS
Parry. Senna adds 3 to her AC against one melee attack that would hit her.

Sample Dialogue: - *Opening: "Step back from the stones! You don't know what you're turning loose!"* - *When pressed: "Harran gave twenty years to this wall. If we let this circle fail, there is no wall left!"* - *When broken: "Gods forgive us… I never wanted anyone to burn."*

SCENE 2 - RIDDLE: CORVEN'S LETTER

Setup: Behind the center dais stone - flush with the back face, sealed with wax that has dried to the color of old amber. A letter, fifty years old, slightly warm to the touch. Players find it during combat (Investigation DC 10 if actively searching the dais) or immediately after, when they have a moment to look.

The Letter:

> *The sun does not belong to the city. It does not belong to the ritual. It does not belong to the ten people who carry it. *It belongs to ___.*

The letter is in Corven's handwriting. Below the blank: *No one should be forced.* His signature. The date: the night of the ritual, fifty years ago. He spent six minutes writing this while dying. Players who think about what that means are doing the work.

Answer: There is no answer written in the letter. The blank is the riddle. Players choose the word or phrase. Whatever they choose becomes the activation word - the signal that triggers the Inversion Circle. It is spoken aloud by whoever stands at the center of the dais.

If players solved the INVERT cipher prop (Session 3): They already have a candidate: *INVERT*. The blank in Corven's letter is an invitation to examine whether they mean it - not whether it's the right vocabulary, but whether the person speaking it genuinely does. The ritual does not check vocabulary. It checks intent. A player who says *"INVERT"* because the puzzle told them to gets the amber-red pulse. A player who says it because they understand what inverting fifty years of darkness means (and accept what that costs) the stones respond.

Correct: Any word chosen through genuine reflection, not rushed, not under duress. The stones respond when it is spoken. There is no mechanical check. The ritual knows.

Wrong (first attempt - players try to skip this and demand the ritual start immediately): The stones glow but do not activate. Tomas looks at whoever is pushing. "He left us a question. We should answer it." The stones wait.

Wrong (third attempt - players propose a word cynically, as a test): The stones pulse once, amber-red rather than amber-gold, and go quiet. The Dawnborn feel it. Ysel says: "That's not it." She doesn't say what it would be. That's not hers to say.

GM Note: The riddle has no answer in the text - only consequences. It is the campaign's moral question made literal. The word the players choose is the word this table carried through five sessions. Make sure they choose it.

SCENE 3 - PUZZLE: THE INVERSION CIRCLE (CORVEN'S ACTIVATION CADENCE)

Setup: The combat from Scene 1 has concluded. Senna's detachment has stood down or retreated; the Ashring plaza has fallen into a tense, breathless quiet. Across the 40-foot circle, all eleven Dawnborn stand at their Primer Stones. The activating word from Corven's Letter has been chosen in Scene 2. But the stones cannot simply be triggered at once—they must be brought into harmonic resonance in Corven's exact astronomical sequence.

The Puzzle - The Activation Cadence: The party must coordinate the stepping order across the 40-foot circle. If Dawnborn step out of sequence, or if more than 6 seconds elapse between steps, the resonance loop collapses and the stones go cold (requiring a DC 15 Arcana check as an action to realign the current).

Decoding the Sequence: The players cross-reference the three clues gathered across the campaign: 1. **The Constellation Glyphs on the Dais Rim:** Arcana DC 12 identifies the glyphs as the stellar coordinates from the First Ritual night fifty years ago, ordered by visual magnitude (brightest to dimmest). 2. **The Spire Inversion Diagram (Session 3):** Marginal note in Corven's hand: *"Cadence: 6 seconds. IX last. Always last."* 3. **Tomas Areth's Memorized Order:** Tomas has kept this sequence in his head for forty years. His personal fear is that his memory might fail under pressure. - *Resolution:* If a player takes 10 minutes (or DC 13 Investigation) to walk Tomas through the dais runes and verify his sequence, Tomas exhales in relief: *"It's right. Every word of it is right."* Tomas steps to Stone 2 without hesitation.

The Execution (The Cadence): The sequence proceeds in astronomical order: 1. **Sera Voss (Stone 1):** Takes her position; the stone beneath her glows pale amber. 2. **Tomas Areth (Stone 2):** Steps on within 6 seconds. The two stones link with a visible ribbon of golden light along the flagstones. 3. **Cormac Drell (Stone 4):** Steps on. The golden line extends across the eastern arc. 4. **Ysel Maren (Stone 3):** Steps on, hands open and relaxed. 5. **Lira Anwick (Stone 5):** Steps on, resolved and steady. 6. **Petra Vane (Stone 6):** Steps on; emerald-gold light rises around her boots. 7. **Nin Fletch (Stone 7):** Steps on, nodding to the party. 8. **Orya Doss (Stone 8):** Steps on, setting her boots firm on the granite. 9. **Aldric Stone (Stone 9) & Davin Shore (Stone 10):** Step on in unison; the southern arc catches fire with deep amber radiance. 10. **Ellan Voss (Stone IX):** Steps on as the tenth element. The ring blazes white-gold. Fifty years of trapped dawn finds its balance. 11. **Ixa (Stone 11 / The Warm Hollow):** The final, uncarved stone. It remains dark until the montage and the party's personal ask in Scene 4.

Complications & Holding the Ring: - *Shaken Nerves:* If any Dawnborn was shoved or targeted during Scene 1 combat, a player must use a Help or Persuasion action (DC 10) to steady them as their count approaches. - *Sound Across the Plaza:* The circle is 40 feet across. A player on the dais can call the cadence cleanly with a clear voice (DC 12 Performance if calling over crowd murmurs, automatic if using a horn, thunderclap, or message spell).

Outcome: All ten perimeter stones lock into continuous golden resonance. The circle hums like an enormous church bell. The Dawnborn stand bathed in light, ready for their Declarations.

SCENE 4 - RP: THE DAWNBORN DECLARE

Five Senses & Setup

NPC: All present Dawnborn, run as a montage, one beat per person, in whatever order they're standing.

Want: To be seen clearly, once, before whatever happens happens.

Fear: That the players will look away, or rush past this, or treat it as preamble to the real scene.

Lie: Most of them are holding something back - not a secret, just the last piece of themselves they've kept private. This scene is where it surfaces, if the players let it.

Setup: At the stones, before the ritual is triggered. The circle is lit or partly lit. The plaza is quiet - the combat is over, the antagonists are gone or standing down. This is the pause before the word is spoken.

Five senses: - Sight: Gold light rising from the stones - not harsh, not blinding. More like early morning through thin curtains. - Sound: The city beyond the Ashring perimeter. Distant. Waiting. - Smell: Warm stone and ozone, fading now. Whatever was electrical about the Ashring is calming. - Touch: The stones themselves warm - not hot, just present. Faintly thrumming. Like a stopped bell still ringing at the edge of perception. - Taste: Cold air. Clean. As if something has already been decided. - Air: Stiller than the plaza has been in fifty years. The held-breath feeling is gone. Something released it.

The Montage - Each Dawnborn

The Encounter Beat - the montage:

- **Sera Voss (Stone 1):** She doesn't address the crowd or the players. She speaks to the stone circle itself: *"I've known since the first bell. I've been ready."* She's been organizing this logistics web for twenty years. This isn't a speech; it is a seal on a ledger finally balanced. The stone beneath her blazes gold.
- **Tomas Areth (Stone 2):** He does not speak. He takes the dense, dog-eared notebook he has carried across forty years, lays it flat on the stone's carved ledge, and weights it with his ink-pot. If a player looks at the open page, the last entry is written in steady ink: *"I chose this."*
- **Ysel Maren (Stone 3):** She catches the eye of whichever player took the time to ask how *she* was doing when everyone else was managing crises. A serene, quiet smile touches her lips: *"I needed someone to ask. Not Edoran. Someone who didn't need the answer to save themselves."* Her hands rest on the granite; it glows with deep amber warmth.
- **Cormac Drell (Stone 4):** *(If his consent was renewed)* He stands broad-shouldered, hands open at his sides. He looks over at the party: *"I set a cup down in an alley because I was terrified of my own reasons. This is me picking it back up."* His stone catches fire with gold light. *(If unresolved, his stone remains dark and cold).*
- **Lira Anwick (Stone 5):** She steps onto the stone, her apothecary apron tucked under her travelling cloak. She doesn't look at the sky; she looks south toward the Lowmark where Mira is safe: *"She will grow up in a world with a morning."* She touches the stone, and it hums with fierce, protective radiance.
- **Petra Vane (Stone 6):** Returned from Greenhollow, smelling of dried mint and wet heather. She looks across the circle directly at Lira. A twenty-year estrangement dissolves in a single, resolute nod between two women who refused to let each other burn alone. Her stone flares emerald-gold.
- **Nin Fletch (Stone 7):** Carpenter's hands resting easily on the stone rim. No longer pacing the Lowmark crossroads: *"I spent two weeks waiting for someone to push me. Turns out I just needed someone to stand with me while I decided."* The stone ignites warm.
- **Orya Doss (Stone 8):** Broad, patient farmer from the northern fields. She draws a fresh piece of charcoal from her pocket, draws a crisp surveyor's circle on the face of the stone—her mark for *'True Landmark'*. *"Same mouth. Same choice."* She steps on; the stone answers with a deep resonance.
- **Aldric Stone (Stone 9):** Broad blacksmith, palms flat on the granite face. His glowing amber eyes reflect the stone's inner fire. He doesn't say a word, but the heat radiating from his position warms everyone within twenty feet. He looks relieved—the long wait for an honest weld is over.
- **Davin Shore (Stone 10):** The grizzled night watchman stands at military attention in his wool guard's cloak. He looks straight into the dark eastern clouds where the sun should be, unbuttons his collar, and taps his chest: *"Told you I'd be looking right at it when it came."* Stone 10 hums like a low church bell.
- **Ellan Voss (Stone IX):** Fifty years after walking away from Corven's circle to protect the life in her womb, she walks into the center of the arc and steps onto Stone IX. No hesitation. No ceremony. She looks across the six-foot gap directly at Ixa: > *"I stepped away once because you needed a voice. I am done stepping away."* The stone under her feet blazes white-gold. Fifty years of trapped twilight suddenly find their true counterweight.
- **Ixa (Stone 11 / The Warm Hollow):** She is standing at the 11th stone—the uncarved hollow in the dais floor that has stayed warm for half a century. Her hands are at her sides, warm as summer sun. She carries the Crucible's ash-tattoos on her neck and shoulder.

She is watching the party. She does not need an argument. She has had three months to make peace with what she is. She is waiting for the party to see *her*.

This is the moment the montage opens into. Give the table silence. Do not rush it.

The Party's Ask - IV-A Payoff

Ixa's player has known from the beginning that this is where her character ends up. She has played toward it across five sessions. She wants the party to be the ones who make it real, not by explaining why it matters, but by asking her, knowing what they're asking.

What Ixa is waiting for: Someone who knows her. Not knows the ritual, not knows the math, not knows what the city needs. Knows *her*. The Crucible survivor. The tabaxi with IV-A's ash in her skin. The person who killed her closest person in an apex trial and carries that person literally in her body. The person who was warm her whole life and never understood why until someone finally told her the truth.

She wants someone to see all of that and ask anyway. Not "will you do this" - *will you.* Knowing who she is. Knowing what they're asking.

What players can say:

About IV-A: Any acknowledgment of IV-A (by name, by the tattoos, by the ash) changes the quality of the air around Ixa. Her hands become warmer. Not warmer than usual. Warmer than they have ever been. The stone beneath her foot begins to warm before she steps on it.

> *"She's in your skin already. She's been going with you the whole time."*

Ixa looks at her hands. She says nothing. She steps on.

About the Crucible: Players who name what the Crucible made her do (not to apologize, not to comfort, just to acknowledge it happened) get this:

> *She is quiet for a moment. Then: "No one has said that out loud to me before." Another moment. "All right. I'll go."*

About what they're asking her: The darkest version. A player says something true - *"I know what this is. I'm asking anyway. Will you?"*

She looks at that player for a long time. Something in her face settles.

> *"Yes. I decided months ago. I just needed someone to ask."*

She steps on. The stone goes white.

The wrong approach: Explaining what the ritual means. Explaining what she'll accomplish. Explaining what the city needs. She knows. She has known for three months. This is not information she needs. If players explain, she waits until they finish, then: *"I already know all of that."* She looks at them. *"Is there something you want to ask me?"*

She is not cruel. She is giving them the chance to try again.

If no one asks - if the table simply stands there: She waits. She is patient in the way someone is patient when they have already decided and are simply waiting for the world to catch up. After a real moment of silence at the table, she says:

> *"I'm going to step on now. If someone wanted to ask me something, this would be the time."*

This is her giving the party the opportunity the player has been building toward. Use it.

GM note: The player whose character is Ixa has been playing toward this for five sessions. This scene belongs to her. Make sure she has time to play it. Don't rush past it to get to the ritual mechanics.

The final beat: Once the other Dawnborn have declared, the table falls quiet. Ixa is the last. Ask a player (any player) out loud: *"What does your character do or say, if anything, before the word is spoken?"* Give them silence and space.

Ixa's stone does not respond to the activation word. It responds to this.

SCENE 5 - COMBAT: HOLD THE DAIS

Setup: One last push. Commander Harran Lecht arrives through the smoke of the eastern approach with four loyal veterans. He does not come to negotiate. He has watched forty years of city life bleed away under twilight, and he believes with fanatical certainty that if the Dawnborn do not burn today, Varenhold falls tomorrow. He is moving to seize the central dais and force the activation before all stones can be secured.

Secondary Objective: Hold the center dais for three rounds while the Dawnborn take their positions. Any player who uses their action on the dais (Dodge, Shield, Help action for a moving Dawnborn) grants that Dawnborn advantage on saving throws and immunity to forced movement until the player's next turn.

Combat End: Three rounds elapse and all eleven positions are occupied, OR Commander Harran Lecht is reduced to 0 HP. The moment Harran falls, his remaining soldiers drop their weapons.

Combat Card - Commander Harran Lecht

COMMANDER HARRAN LECHT
Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral (tragic fanatic)
Lord Commander of the Reckoning. A war-weary man hollowed out by duty, moving on pure adrenaline, grief, and unbroken stubbornness.

AC 17 (scarred half-plate) · **HP** 102 (12d8+48) · **Speed** 30 ft.
STR 18 (+4) · **DEX** 12 (+1) · **CON** 18 (+4) · **INT** 12 (+1) · **WIS** 10 (+0) · **CHA** 16 (+3)
Saving Throws Str +7, Con +7, Wis +3 · **Skills** Athletics +7, Intimidation +6, Perception +3
Condition Immunities Frightened, charmed · **Senses** Passive Perception 13 · **Languages** Common · **CR** 6 (2,300 XP)

TRAITS
Desperate Conviction. While below 50 HP (bloodied), Harran gains +2 to all attack rolls and deals an additional 4 (1d8) damage with his broadsword. His armor is battered, his breathing ragged, but he will not stop.
Iron Command. Allied soldiers within 30 ft of Harran add +1d4 to their attack rolls and cannot be charmed or frightened while Harran is conscious.
The Unforgiving Choice. Harran cannot be persuaded to abandon his attack with words alone; only reducing him to 0 HP or completing the 11-stone circle in front of his eyes will break his conviction.

ACTIONS
Multiattack. Harran makes three attacks: two with his Heavy Broadsword and one with his Shield Slam.
Heavy Broadsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit (+9 if bloodied), reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 11 (2d6+4) slashing damage (+ 4 (1d8) if bloodied). *A brutal, two-handed military cleave driven by desperation.*
Shield Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d8+4) bludgeoning damage. Target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone and pushed 5 ft back.
Rally the Lost (Recharge 5–6). As a bonus action, Harran roars a battle cry: *"Hold the line! For Varenhold!"* All allied Veterans within 30 ft immediately gain 15 temporary hit points and can move up to their speed toward the dais.

REACTIONS
Unyielding Parry. Harran adds +3 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him.

TACTICS & BEAT: - *Round 1:* Harran charges directly for the center dais, bellowing: *"Step away! You're gambling with five hundred thousand lives! I will not let you damn this city to another century of twilight!"* - *Round 2:* Uses Shield Slam to knock party frontliners away from the dais, attempting to position a soldier to strike the inscription. - *Round 3:* Bloodied and desperate. He ignores opportunity attacks to reach whoever holds Corven's box or stands at the center stone.

When Harran Goes Down (Encounter Beat): He falls to one knee, the broadsword slipping from his numb fingers. He does not rage. He looks up at the standing stones.
- **If all eleven stones are glowing gold:** He stares in stunned, trembling silence. He presses one bloodied hand to the flagstones.
> *"It didn't ask for blood… It was never supposed to ask for blood…"*
He closes his eyes and bows his head. He does not resist arrest. - **If stones are dark:**
> *"I was trying… I was trying to fix what they broke fifty years ago. Who will keep the wall when the frost comes?"*

Into the Ritual: The plaza falls dead silent. The Reckoning veterans lower their weapons. Eleven positions are occupied. The activation word waits in the silence.

THE RITUAL MOMENT

The Ashring. Whatever stones are lit, whatever stones are dark. Players have the activation word. The Dawnborn are at their positions or they aren't.

Give the table a moment of actual silence (ten to fifteen seconds) before asking: "Who speaks?"

Ixa's stone - the 11th element:

Ten stones glow when their Dawnborn steps on them. Ixa's stone is waiting for something different. Not consent - she consented three months ago, alone, alone, three months before she chose to walk to the Ashring. What the stone is waiting for is the thing she decided she needed to see first.

She has watched everything. Five sessions of people making choices under pressure. She has watched Harran become less than he was. She has watched Cormac set down a cup very carefully and walk out a door and come back. She has watched Ellan Voss step onto a stone fifty years after the moment she couldn't. She has been watching to understand if people are worth what she carries. Whether returning it to the sky is a fair trade for what happens to the city. Whether the exchange is actually just.

She is standing at the 11th stone. Not on it. Her hands are at her sides. Her hands are warm.

She has already decided. She is waiting for something to confirm it. Not something about the ritual. Something about people.

What her stone responds to: A genuine human moment - not an argument, not an explanation of the stakes, not a speech about what she means to the mission. The stone responds when someone sees her fully (knowing what she is, knowing what stepping on means) and does something human anyway. Something small. Something that has nothing to do with saving the city.

It is not a skill check. There is no wrong answer that isn't an argument. There is no right answer that isn't just a person.

WHAT A PLAYER DOES	WHAT HAPPENS
Offers their hand, not to lead her to the stone, just because	She looks at the hand for a long moment. Then she takes it. She steps on.
Says something true, not about the ritual, just something true about her or about themselves	Her stone warms before she moves. She notices. She exhales. She steps on.
Says nothing, simply stands beside her and waits	She looks at them for a long time. Then, quietly: *"Okay."* She steps on.
Tells her what she means to the ritual, what her stepping on will accomplish	Her stone stays cold. She has heard this. She has known this for three months. This is not what she was waiting for.

If players know and act anyway: This is the most devastating version. They know what stepping on costs her. They extend a hand knowing. She knows they know. This is not deception and it is not cowardice. It is two people acknowledging a true thing and choosing to do it together. The stone goes white.

If players don't know: The stone goes white. The dawn rises. And then someone looks at where Ixa was standing, and understands. This is a different kind of devastating. Both are honest.

Before she steps, she looks at whoever asked her. Then at her own hands - the ash tattoos on her neck and shoulder, IV-A's ashes pressed into skin, briefly warm in a way that has nothing to do with the Primer Stone. She looks at them for a long moment.

> *"I've been warm my whole life. I always thought it was hers."*

She steps on.

When the stone lights, it does not glow gold like the others. It goes white (briefly, startlingly white, the color of something that has been waiting a very long time) and then settles as it joins the circle. Eleven stones. A complete ring of light, for the first time in fifty years. Maybe ever.

The activation word can be spoken now.

Ending B - The Inversion (all eleven stones lit)

The word is spoken from the center of the dais. All eleven Dawnborn speak it simultaneously - the players hear their voices overlap across the circle. The amber light doesn't flash. It doesn't surge. It changes quality. Something in the air shifts - the particular heaviness that Varenhold has carried for fifty years lifts, the way a held breath releases. The stones go cold. The Dawnborn are still standing.

All of them.

And then someone notices.

Ixa's stone goes cold last. By the time the players look toward it, it is dark. She was standing there. Her hands were warm.

She is not there.

There is no dramatic exit. No body. No visible departure. The ritual energy returned to the sky and she went with it - the way the sun returns each morning, without announcing itself, simply happening. Her stone is the only one without a person standing beside it. Her stone is the only one already cold.

Sera looks at her hands. She starts laughing. She cannot explain why. She does not know why. She will not be able to explain it for days, the laughter that came before the understanding did.

Players who were beside Ixa (who offered their hand, who stood in silence, who said something true) have a moment to decide what they do with that. There is no correct response. There is only what they do.

Ellan Voss, if present: She is still standing at her stone. She has not moved. If a player looks at her face: she knows. She has known since the moment she stepped on. She chose to step on anyway. This is what it looks like when someone makes the same choice twice, fifty years apart, for the same reason - because you cannot give consent for someone who has no voice yet, and Ixa had a voice, and she used it.

Ellan does not cry. She has been crying, in various ways, for fifty years. She is done.

The sun does not rise immediately. It rises the next morning, for the first time in fifty years. The players have the night to wait with what they carry. They can spend it however they need to.

In the morning, the first light is not amber. It is gold. The real kind. The kind the city forgot.

Ending A - Willing Sacrifice (8–10 stones lit, Ixa's stone cold)

Ixa did not step on her stone. She is standing beside it, watching.

The willing Dawnborn complete the ritual without the 11th element. Without Ixa, the energy has nowhere clean to return - it cannot invert, it can only release. The Dawnborn who consented give everything they carry. The stone positions of the willing go quiet - not dramatically, not loudly, just quiet. The sky changes. The players know who is gone before anyone says it.

The stones are cold. The Dawnborn who consented are not standing anymore.

Ixa's stone is the only one still slightly warm. She does not pull her hand back from it. She stands there for a long time. She understands, now, what her being here would have meant. She understands it clearly and completely and she has no one to be angry at.

The sun rises the next morning. For the first time in fifty years.

The remaining Dawnborn are alive. The city will recover. The sky is real again. These things are true.

The other things are also true. Both fit in the morning light.

Ending C - The Transfer (Isolde's apparatus)

(Isolde Rann: former Compact researcher, fifty years gone. Her redirect apparatus was recovered and partially rebuilt in Session 4 from the Compact's restricted archive. Players must have found and reconstructed it in Session 4 for this ending to be available. If they did not, it is unavailable.)

The apparatus hums as the energy redirects. The Dawnborn are pale, shaking, but standing. The sky at the horizon changes color - amber becoming gold. There is a 15–20% chance one stone goes cold. The GM decides before the session whether this happens. If it does: it happens quietly, without drama. The Dawnborn at that stone sits down slowly, and the others catch them.

Whether Ixa's stone activated determines whether the transfer reaches full coherence or achieves something partial and costly.

Ending D - Refusal

The players stand in the Ashring and do not speak. The Dawnborn leave, one by one. Sera is last.

She looks at the players for a long moment. She does not argue. She does not explain. Then, quietly, without anger: *"I was ready."* She picks up her crossbow and walks out of the Ashring without looking back.

Ixa watches her go. Then she looks at the players. She does not say anything either. She leaves.

The city will adapt, or it won't. This is a valid ending. It says some things are worth more than the sun.

Ending E - Cascade Failure

(Players allow Reckoning or other antagonists to position unwilling Dawnborn)

The circle breaks. The energy releases without coherence - not a ritual, a rupture. All stones go cold at once. The sky over the Ashring blazes amber for thirty seconds and then goes dark. Harran is on his knees in the plaza. He is not hurt. He is quiet. You are the people in this room who know exactly what just happened and why.

Ixa’s stone was the coldest of all. It never warmed.

THE SIX ENDINGS - READ ALOUD TEXT

Read the appropriate passage aloud. Then close the book.

A - The Willing Sacrifice

Read aloud: "The ones who chose are gone. Not violently - not dramatically. They are simply no longer here, and the sun is. The city will make them saints, which is a kind of forgetting. You are the people in this room who know the difference between what happened and what the songs will say happened. That is yours to carry."

B - The Inversion

Read aloud: "The sun rises. The Dawnborn are alive. Sera is still laughing. Tomas is looking at his notebook and not writing in it. Lira is already gone - she left to get back to Mira before the sun comes up. And Ixa's stone went cold last - just a second after all the others. She was standing at it when it happened. She's still standing there. This is the ending that required everyone to be asked and everyone to answer. It required you to see her. Varenhold doesn't know that yet. It will."

C - The Transfer

Read aloud: "The sun rises. Most of the Dawnborn are alive. One, maybe two - the stones tell you before the morning does. Isolde's method worked, which is not the same as it being perfect. You solved a problem. The problem had a cost. The cost was smaller than the alternatives. You will spend a long time deciding if that was enough."

D - The Refusal

Read aloud: "The sun stays dark. The Dawnborn go home. The city finds out, in the next month, that the investigators it hired chose the Dawnborn over the ritual - and the city's reaction is not simple, because the city is not simple. You chose something. You'll spend a long time learning what."

E - Cascade Failure

Read aloud: "The circle breaks. The energy releases without coherence - not a ritual, a rupture. All stones go cold at once. The sky over the Ashring blazes amber for thirty seconds and then goes dark. Harran is on his knees in the plaza. He is not hurt. He is quiet. You are the people in this room who know exactly what just happened and why."

F - The Long Dark

Read aloud: "The seven days passed. Then more days. The Dawnborn are alive. The food stores are lower. The sun is dark. Varenhold is not dead - cities rarely die quickly. It adapts. You left. Or you stayed. The sun stays dark either way."

THE DEBRIEF

Not optional. The fifteen minutes after Session 5 are part of the experience.

Ask each player in turn, not rhetorically, with a pause between each question and each answer:

1. “What did your character do right? What are they sure of?”
2. “What are they not sure of?”
3. “When the right choice and the good choice were different - which did they make? Do they know the difference?”

Do not answer these for them. Do not wrap up the moral question. Let it sit.

If a player tries to resolve it: “The campaign doesn’t answer that. That’s yours to carry.”

END OF SESSION

What players now know: - What the sun costs, or what it cost - Whether the Dawnborn chose, and whether the choice was free - What they would do differently

What they carry forward: The question the campaign never answered, and the certainty that they answered it anyway.

Session debrief question: *“When the ‘right’ choice and the ‘good’ choice were different - which did your character make? Do they know?”*

Consequence tracker:

ELEMENT	STATE
Ending	B (Inversion) / A (Sacrifice) / C (Transfer) / D (Refusal) / E (Cascade) / F (Long Dark)
Ellan’s final act	Stepped onto her stone freely / Did not come
Ixa’s stone	Lit: she returned to the light / Cold: she did not step on
What activated Ixa’s stone	*(record exactly what the player did or said; this moment belongs to the record)*
Did players know what stepping on meant	Yes: they knew / No: they found out after
Cormac’s stone	Lit / Cold
Lira’s stone	Lit / Cold
Harran’s final state	Witnessed the ritual / Went down fighting / Talked down by Senna
Senna Kard	De-escalated mid-combat / Fought to the end / Not present
Keseph Vyne	Under inquiry / Confronted after ritual / Never surfaced
Varren Aldiss	Exposed / Never surfaced
The activation word	*(record what the players chose)*
The debrief	Done / Skipped

What the city will remember:

Varenhold will make saints of this. The songs will not be accurate. The songs will say ten people saved the city. They will not mention the eleventh. Or they will mention her as a miracle - a child touched by the ritual, who stood in the right place at the right moment. They will not say she chose. They will not say she knew. The people in this room are the ones who know what actually happened. That is theirs to carry.

Corven spent six minutes writing a blank that took fifty years to fill. The word the table chose is the word this campaign carried. Write it down. It belongs to the record.

Ixa’s hands were warm. Until they weren’t.

SESSION 5 TACTICAL REFERENCE MAPS

The Ashring - Final Configuration (Scenes 1–5)

Leave on table for the entire session. Mark stone status as the session progresses: fill each position with the Dawnborn's name when they arrive; circle it when their stone activates; cross it out if a stone goes dark.

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THE ASHRING - SESSION 5 TRACKING MAP              SCALE: 1:50
Fill in each position as Dawnborn arrive. Mark: LIT / DARK.


                  [  1 - NORTH  ]
                  SERA VOSS
                  Status: ______

   [ 10 ]                              [  2  ]
   DAVIN SHORE                         TOMAS ARETH
   Status: ______                      Status: ______

[  9  ]                                        [  3  ]
ALDRIC STONE                                   YSEL MAREN
Status: ______          ┌──────────┐           Status: ______
                        │  CENTER  │
[  8  ]                 │   DAIS   │           [  4  ]
ORYA DOSS               │ (75 HP)  │           CORMAC DRELL
Status: ______          └──────────┘           Status: ______

[  7  ]                                        [  5  ]
NIN FLETCH                                     LIRA ANWICK
Status: ______                                 Status: ______

      [  IX / 11 ]                 [  6  ]
      ELLAN VOSS & IXA             PETRA VANE
      Status: ______               Status: ______

DAIS HP: 75. If dais takes 75+ damage: Inversion still works
but requires DC 18 Arcana from whoever speaks the word.

CIRCLE DIAMETER: 40ft. Shouting reaches all positions IF quiet.
If not quiet: DC 14 Performance to be heard across the circle.
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Ashring Plaza - Last Stand Combat (Scene 1 and Scene 5)

GM reference for the two combat scenes. The Reckoning arrives from the east approach road. Solennite Blades (if present) move for the dais. Senna (if not de-escalated) arrives from the south.

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ASHRING PLAZA - COMBAT REFERENCE MAP              SCALE: 1:75


[NORTH EXIT - residential lane beyond. Civilians are gone.]

▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒ STONE CIRCLE (40ft ring) ▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒▒
▒  Primer Stones at perimeter; center dais raised 5ft.      ▒
▒  Difficult terrain: loose flagstone around eastern arc.   ▒
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[EAST APPROACH ROAD] ←── RECKONING arrives here
                         8 Veterans + Harran Lecht

[SOUTH LANE] ←── SENNA'S approach (if present)
                 Also: players' likely entry from session 4

[WEST - market stalls, closed. Cover but no concealment.]

[SOLENNITE BLADES target] ← center dais, if present

CROWD (civilian observers, Session 5 only):
40-60 people at plaza perimeter. Not combatants. Each round
of visible combat: DC 10 Persuasion from any Dawnborn to keep
them from scattering and breaking formation sight lines.
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